are also held up as new avenues for job creation, in an effort to counter the Opposition jibes of joblessness. The prime minister himself has on multiple occasions distributed appointment letters to newly-inducted recruits.

What the Youth Vote For

Will the youth buy into these poll promises? Even as they hold out a basket of hope for the young electorate, political parties themselves forever tread the unknown line between expectation of vote and the actual casting of it. The youth are not a monolithic bloc, nor do they vote as one. Their issues may be common—jobs and price rise—and may also vary across geographies. Or, they may not matter at all. Caste, community, family, candidate and popular perceptions could influence their voting decision instead.

The youth are not a monolithic bloc nor vote as one. Their choice is not always issue-based, often it is also determined by caste, community, family, the candidate and popular perceptions

In what is also emerging as a matter of growing concern, the enthusiasm among first-time voters has seen a dip this time, with only 38 per cent of the eligible voters registering to vote. In three electorally critical states—Uttar Pradesh, Bihar and Maharashtra accounting for 168 Lok Sabha seats—the average registration rate is less than 22 per cent. This despite the Election Commission running multiple initiatives, including recent ones such as 'Turning 18' and 'You are the One', on social media platforms. Experts attribute the current apathy to several factors. Former chief election commissioner Om Prakash Rawat thinks it is because of complacency or a sense of inevitability about the result. "Several youngsters I spoke to are sure of the outcome," he says. "They feel their votes are not going to make any difference to the eventual result."

If the BJP rode on the desire for change in 2014, Pulwama-invoked nationalism in 2019, it is hoping this election will be about the Ram mandir. But there's also the anti-incumbency of 10 years. The first-time voter in this election has not known any other government and, therefore, has nothing to measure it against. Hence the PM's reminders to young voters in public rallies to ask their parents about the "misrule" of the past. Or his "*pariksha pe charcha*" interactions with school students. "In 2014, Prime Minister Modi's campaign offered hope of change to the youth," says Major General Anil Verma (retd), head of the Association for Democratic Reforms. "After two terms, the youth may not have seen all the changes they had expected for various reasons, including the pandemic. So, naturally the enthusiasm among them may be wearing out."

Getting Them to the Booth

Their anti-establishment psyche may be one of the reasons for the youth's current indifference, according to Tiwari. Yet he and most political observers don't discern any anti-BJP wave among the youth. "The drop in enthusiasm among youngsters for the BJP may have narrowed the gap in their support for the party and the Opposition. However, they are still overwhelmingly backing the BJP," says Rahul Verma, fellow, Centre for Policy Research.

Also, as Snigdha Poonam, journalist and author of *Dreamers: How Young Indians are Changing the World*, says, "In my conversations with first-time voters, I found that most of them were so inextricably caught up with studies, exams, coaching and career dilemmas that elections hadn't yet emerged as an important event in their lives."

In a recent survey conducted by Asar Social Impact Advisors and the Climate Education Network across four states—Tamil Nadu, Maharashtra, Delhi and West Bengal—the first-time voters unanimously said that commitment to climate action by a party or candidate would be among the top three factors dictating their voting choice. Unfortunately, climate change has yet to be part of the electoral narrative, even in the national capital, which is among the most polluted cities in the world. Not surprisingly, the first-time voter enrolment rate in Delhi is an abysmal 21 per cent.

All of which make it imperative that all stakeholders eliminate the systemic barriers to youth participation in the democratic process. Some say the ECI needs to simplify the enrolment process further after migrating online. For a generation that has grown up on quick communication and digital financial transactions, a lengthy online registration process often acts as a deterrent. "If it is made as easy and simple as opening a new bank account or UPI ID, it will help young people enrol as voters," says Nikhil Taneja, co-founder and chief, Yuvaa, a youth-centric non-profit. Given the sheer size of the voting population of the youth and their ability to influence voting trends it's important that all effort is made to get them to vote on election day. ■

with **Amitabh Srivastava** *and* **Dhaval S. Kulkarni**